

Chapter 4

The Apprehensional construction in Gban

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This paper focuses on the dedicated Apprehensional construction in Gban (South Mande, Côte d'Ivoire), which expresses several meanings related to fear or undesirability. The Apprehensional construction is used in main clauses and in dependent clauses. In main clauses, three readings or functions can be identified: expressing pure apprehension, warning, and threat. Two different dependent uses have been attested: in 'fear' predicate complements and in negative purpose clauses. The paper describes the formal make-up of the construction, its semantic and syntactic properties, its relation to negative polarity and to the grammatical system of Gban in general. Diachronic sources for the elements comprising the construction and possible scenarios of its grammaticalization are proposed.

1 Introduction

Gban (*gbá*; ISO 639-3 code: ggu, Glottocode: gagu1242) (Fedotov 2016, 2017, 2021) is a South Mande language spoken by about 60,000 people in the central part of Côte d'Ivoire. This study is based on the Bovo dialect.

Gban has a dedicated grammatical construction that expresses meanings belonging to the apprehensional semantic domain (the domain of fear and undesirability) (Lichtenberk 1995, Dobrushina 2006, Vuillermet 2018, Vuillermet et al. 2026 [this volume]) – henceforth the *Apprehensional construction*.

The Apprehensional construction in Gban covers almost all meanings/uses that are cross-linguistically associated with the apprehensional domain. It has main-clause uses (expressing pure apprehension, warning, or threat), uses in



‘fear’ predicate complements, and uses in negative purpose (= precautioning) clauses.

Both the construction and the semantic domain may be provisionally illustrated by examples (1)–(3).

- (1) Main-clause pure-apprehension use

É! W-ǎ nù ké ì mɔ wòtló kũǎ!

oh 3PL-APPR APPR EMPH I for car steal[INF]

[The speaker has left his/her car outside for the night unattended. He/she is now in bed, talking to him/herself, just expressing his/her anxiety:] ‘— Oh, my car **might** get stolen!’

- (2) ‘Fear’ predicate complement

È gbě [ní Flǎsóá (y)-ǎ nù gá].

3SG IPFV\be_afraid that François 3SG-APPR APPR die[INF]

‘She’s **afraid** that François **might** die.’

- (3) Negative purpose

Ǿ nũ kwà zǝ è dí [í gwà y-ǎ

3PL IPFV\come arm descend[INF] you_SG under that stone 3SG-APPR

nù è kpě kplǝ lě].

APPR you_SG foot scratch[INF] because

‘[T]hey will lift you up in their hands, **so that** you will **not** strike your foot against a stone.’ (Luke 4:11)

This paper will explore in detail the different types of uses, as well as other properties of the construction. Some typologically relevant parameters will be discussed for each use/reading, including its compatibility with different grammatical persons, with situations located in the past, the present, and the future, and with preventable and unpreventable situations.

In §2, I will describe the formal properties of the Apprehensional construction. In §3, I will discuss its paradigmatic status with respect to other core grammatical constructions of Gban. In §4, the usage of the construction in main clauses will be discussed, with the three attested readings/functions: expression of pure apprehension (§4.1), warnings (§4.2), and threats (§4.3). In §5, I will describe the two types of syntactically dependent uses: ‘fear’ predicate complement uses (§5.1) and negative-purpose uses (§5.2). In §6, I will present the most probable diachronic sources for the elements comprising the Apprehensional construction and propose possible scenarios of its grammaticalization as a whole. Finally, in §7, I will separately discuss the synchronic relation of the Apprehensional construction to polarity.

The study is based on field data (elicitation and spontaneous texts) from the Bovo dialect collected in Côte d'Ivoire in 2011–2020, as well as on the text of the New Testament translation (Howard et al. 1998). Elicitation was partially guided by Marine Vuillermet's "Questionnaire on the apprehensional domain" (Vuillermet 2026 [this volume]). Most of the description is built on elicited data.¹ Examples from spontaneous texts and from the New Testament will be marked accordingly ("Narrative text", "2 John 1:8", etc.), while elicited examples will be left unmarked.

In the examples throughout the paper, I use the following notation. A superscript "OK" before an example indicates that the whole example was constructed by me in Gban and then was approved by the speaker as felicitous (while an asterisk "*" or one or several "?" indicate a greater or lesser degree of infelicitousness). Examples without "OK" were translated from French into Gban, suggested by the speaker in the course of the discussion, or taken from texts. The symbol "#" before an example indicates that the sentence is either a) grammatically correct, but was said to be nonsensical, or b) cannot be used with the given interpretation (but may be absolutely felicitous with some other interpretation, which is irrelevant to the discussion). Square brackets "[]" are used in some of the translations to indicate those semantic components (or a more general context) which are not explicitly expressed in the example. Curly brackets "{ }" are used to enclose the translation of the omitted parts of the example (which had been present in the Gban text, but which I removed for reasons of space). A tilde "~" is placed before some translations to mark them as approximate (including those cases where the translation was missing from the data and I produced a provisional one myself). Additionally, for some examples I provide not only the English translation, but also, in parentheses, the original (vernacular) French translation given by the speaker.

2 Form

The Apprehensional construction in Gban contains a dedicated predicative marker² -ã/-ǎ 'APPR' at the beginning of the clause and a dedicated invariable

¹This is partially due to the fact that the construction is very infrequent in the texts (except for the negative-purpose uses, see §5.2), and partially because only elicitation made possible a fine-grained study of the semantics of the construction and of different combinations of the examined parameters. Still, it would have been desirable, of course, to have more examples from natural texts in the data.

²Predicative markers are special grammatical markers that are placed right after the subject NP and that participate in the expression of TAM and other sentential grammatical categories (i.e. categories pertaining to the whole predication, hence the term *predicative*). See §3 for more details on predicative markers and the grammatical system of Gban in general.

auxiliary verb *nù* (glossed here as ‘APPR’, too), which introduces the zero-marked infinitive form of the main verb:

- (4) *N-ǎ nù è blě è kwà ylē.*
 2SG-APPR APPR you_SG self you_SG arm break[INF]
 ‘[It would be bad if] you (sg.) broke your arms [this way]’,
 ‘You might break your arms [this way]’ (to a child playing on a staircase);
 ‘[Be careful not to] break your arms!’

A sample paradigm of the Apprehensional construction with the lexical verb *nù* ‘come’ and different person-number markers is presented in Table 1. (While formally identical to the Apprehensional auxiliary, this second *nù* is not part of the apprehensional construction, but the infinitive form of ‘come’, see further §6.)

Table 1: Apprehensional construction in combination with different person-number markers: ‘[I’m afraid that] I/we/you (sg./pl.)/(s)he/they might come’.

	SG			PL		
1st	<i>m-ǎ</i>	<i>nù</i>	<i>nù</i>	<i>w-ǎ</i>	<i>nù</i>	<i>nù</i>
	1SG-APPR	APPR	come[INF]	1PL-APPR	APPR	come[INF]
2nd	<i>n-ǎ</i>	<i>nù</i>	<i>nù</i>	<i>ǎ-ǎ</i>	<i>nù</i>	<i>nù</i>
	2SG-APPR	APPR	come[INF]	2PL-APPR	APPR	come[INF]
3rd	<i>y-ǎ</i>	<i>nù</i>	<i>nù</i>	<i>w-ǎ</i>	<i>nù</i>	<i>nù</i>
	3SG-APPR	APPR	come[INF]	3PL-APPR	APPR	come[INF]

It is important to distinguish the predicative marker *-ǎ/-ǎ* ‘APPR’ from a quasi-homonymous (although most certainly diachronically related, see §6) predicative marker *-ǎ/-ǎ* ‘SBJV.NEG’ in the Negative Subjunctive construction. The latter, too, has two allomorphs *-ǎ* and *-ǎ*, but these have a slightly different distribution. A sample paradigm is given in Table 2. Note that this construction does not involve an auxiliary and features a different form of the verb with a different tone pattern.

The subtle difference in the form of the marker itself can be seen in the 2nd person. For the Apprehensional predicative marker, an allomorph *-ǎ* with an extra-high tone is chosen, while the Negative Subjunctive marker has an allomorph *-ǎ* with a rising tone.³

³In the case of the 2nd-person plural marker, this is realized as spanning over two vowels: *ǎǎ*.

Table 2: Negative Subjunctive construction in combination with different person-number markers: ‘I/we/we and you (pl.)/you (sg./pl.)/(s)he/they shouldn’t come.’

	SG		PL/PL_INCL	
1st	<i>m-ǎ</i>	<i>nũ</i>	<i>w-ǎ</i>	<i>nũ</i>
	1SG-SBJV.NEG	IPFV\come	1PL-SBJV.NEG	IPFV\come
			<i>à(ù)w-ǎ</i>	<i>nũ</i>
			1PL_INCL.SBJV-SBJV.NEG	IPFV\come
2nd	<i>n-ǎ</i>	<i>nũ</i>	<i>ǎǎ</i>	<i>nũ</i>
	2SG-SBJV.NEG	IPFV\come	2PL-SBJV.NEG	IPFV\come
3rd	<i>y-ǎ</i>	<i>nũ</i>	<i>w-ǎ</i>	<i>nũ</i>
	3SG-SBJV.NEG	IPFV\come	3PL-SBJV.NEG	IPFV\come

At the same time, a predicative marker that is formally fully identical to *-ǎ/-ǎ* ‘APPR’ is used in another construction, the Enimitive construction,⁴ which has the totally unrelated meaning/function ‘... isn’t it?, ... right?; indeed, certainly’. A sample paradigm for the construction is presented in Table 3 and an illustration of its use in example (5) below.

- (5) *N-ǎ yěě yǒ nĩ!*
 2SG-ENIM IPFV\be there ENIM
 [To a person who is standing close to two children fighting, but isn’t trying to pull them apart:] ‘— [Hey!] You’re [standing] there, **aren’t you!**’
 [Why aren’t you doing something?]

As can be seen, while sharing the predicative marker *-ǎ/-ǎ* with the Apprehensional construction, the Enimitive construction formally differs from it by the lack of the invariable auxiliary *nũ* and the presence of a special clause-final particle *nĩ* and also by the fact that the Enimitive construction combines with finite (inflecting) forms of the main verb.

⁴In this construction, this marker will be glossed as ‘ENIM’ for convenience, although it could be glossed in both constructions as ‘APPR/ENIM’ (or with some simplex gloss that would somehow cover the functions of both constructions). Any such decision is arbitrary, since it is not clear whether *-ǎ/-ǎ* ‘APPR’ and *-ǎ/-ǎ* ‘ENIM’ should be considered synchronically as one and the same marker or as two different homonymous ones.

In using this label, I follow Panov (2020), who suggested the term *enimitive* for a very close range of meanings (the term itself is derived from the Latin particle *enim* expressing similar semantics).

Table 3: Enimitive construction (in Non-past) in combination with different person-number markers: ‘I/we/you (sg./pl.)/(s)he/they come(s) indeed.’

	SG			PL		
1st	<i>m-ǎ</i>	<i>nǔ</i>	<i>nì</i>	<i>w-ǎ</i>	<i>nǔ</i>	<i>nì</i>
	1SG-ENIM	IPFV\come	ENIM	1PL-ENIM	IPFV\come	ENIM
2nd	<i>n-ǎ</i>	<i>nǔ</i>	<i>nì</i>	<i>ǎǎ</i>	<i>nǔ</i>	<i>nì</i>
	2SG-ENIM	IPFV\come	ENIM	2PL-ENIM	IPFV\come	ENIM
3rd	<i>y-ǎ</i>	<i>nǔ</i>	<i>nì</i>	<i>w-ǎ</i>	<i>nǔ</i>	<i>nì</i>
	3SG-ENIM	IPFV\come	ENIM	3PL-ENIM	IPFV\come	ENIM

3 Paradigmatic status

The Apprehensional construction is an integral part of the grammatical tense-aspect-mood system of Gban, and can be shown to be one of its core sentential constructions.⁵

As mentioned above, the Apprehensional construction contains a predicative marker *-ǎ/-ǎ* ‘APPR’. Let us first discuss the predicative markers in general.

Gban has an SOV word order. The predicative markers make up five rigid consecutive slots at the beginning of the sentence, right after the subject NP (if present) and before the direct object NP and the verb. In each of these slots, only one marker can appear at a time; all five of them can be occupied simultaneously by non-zero markers. An overview of the predicative marker system is given in Table 4, with the Apprehensional predicative marker in bold.

As for the verb forms, the (finite) verb can have four different tonal forms, see Table 5. First, the verb can retain its lexical tone (i.e. no tonal changes occur). Such unmarked forms express the Affirmative Subjunctive, the Imperative, the Polite Imperative, and the Perfective Hodiernal Past (and also the non-finite form of the

⁵They are regarded as sentential and not verbal because they are not expressed (solely) by finite verb forms, but by sentence-level constructions that combine predicative markers and finite verb forms; see below.

By a *core* grammatical construction (opposed to a *peripheral* one) I understand a construction that belongs to a certain closed set of grammatical constructions from which it is obligatory to choose and employ one (and only one) construction whenever one utters a finite clause in this language.

Table 4: The structure of the predicative marker slots and their linear position in the sentence.

S	PMs ^a					(DO)	V ...
	Slot 1 ^b	Slot 2	Slot 3	Slot 4	Slot 5		
	<i>ĩ/m(ĩ)</i> '1SG'	-Ø 'NEUTR'	-Ø 'NCOND.AFF'	-Ø 'NPST'	-Ø 'NIPFVPST' ^c		
	<i>ù/w(i)/wù</i> '1PL'	-lí/-lè 'FOC'	-kè/-à 'IND.NEG'	- [†] 'PST' ^d	-è 'IPFV.HEST'		
	<i>àù/à(ù)w</i> '1PL_INCL.SBJV'	-lè(è) 'PRSV'	-kě" 'COND.AFF'		-é 'IPFV.PREH'		
	<i>è/n(ĩ)</i> '2SG'		-kě 'COND.NEG'				
	<i>bě</i> '2SG.SBJV'		-ǎ/-ǎ 'SBJV.NEG'				
	Ø '2SG.IMP'		-ǎ/-ǎ 'APPR/ENIM'				
	<i>bě</i> '2SG.IMP_POL'						
	<i>à</i> '2PL'						
	<i>ě"/"/Ø/y(ě)</i> '3SG'						
	<i>ǎ"/"/Ø/w(ǎ)</i> '3PL'						

^aThe predicative markers (PMs) are located between the subject (S) and the direct object (DO) or the (intransitive) verb (V). Several non-obligatory predicative markers can occur after Slot 5; they are not presented here. There are a few restrictions on combinations, but in general, most semantically coherent combinations of markers in different slots are possible.

^bThe person-number markers in Slot 1 have complex allomorphy; only the first few allomorphs are listed.

^cTwo of the glosses for zero markers, 'NCOND' and 'NIPFVPST', are simplified: for 'NCOND', see Footnote 8; 'NIPFVPST' stands for 'everything else but Imperfective Hesternal/Pre-hesternal Past'.

^dThe Past predicative marker -[†] is a tonal morpheme that shifts the tone of the preceding syllable two levels up.

Table 5: The four finite verb forms

Form	Example and gloss
Unmarked (zero) forms	<i>gò</i> ‘buy[...]’ ^a
Imperfective	<i>sǎ gǒ</i> ‘house IPFV \buy’
Perfective Hesternal Past	<i>gǒ</i> ‘buy\ PFV . HEST ’
Perfective Pre-hesternal Past	<i>gǒ</i> ‘buy\ PFV . PREH ’

^aThe three dots stand for a number of different glosses for different zero forms, see Footnote 6.

Infinitive).⁶ Second, the verb can become a tonal enclitic, copying onto itself the tone of the last syllable of the preceding word (such as the direct object *sã* ‘house’ in the example below). This form expresses the Imperfective; it is also used in all Non-past and Negative Subjunctive constructions. Third and fourth, there are two forms where the verb acquires a fixed grammatical tone. The extra-low tone expresses the Perfective Hesternal Past, and the rising tone the Perfective Prehesternal Past.

When combined, the paradigms of bound predicative markers described above, together with different forms of the verb (and sometimes with some other additional elements) form Gban's seven sentential grammatical categories: person-number, informational status, mood, polarity, tense, temporal distance, and aspect. Examples (6) and (7) illustrate combinations of members of these categories.

- (6) $\text{\textcircled{E}}\text{-l\`e-k\`e}^1\text{-\textcircled{e}}$ $\text{\textcircled{a}}$ $\text{\textcircled{t\`a}}$   $\text{\textcircled{s\`e}}$.
 3SG-FOC-IND.NEG-PST-IPFV.HEST he/she/it IPFV\ sow today
 ‘It’s him who wasn’t going to sow it today.’
 (3rd person sg. + Subject focus + Indicative + Negative + Past + Hesternal
 + Imperfective)
- (7) $\text{\textcircled{S\`ok\`u}} \text{\textcircled{\text{e}}}\text{-}\text{\textcircled{\text{e}}}\text{-}\text{\textcircled{\text{e}}}^1\text{-}\text{\textcircled{\text{e}}}^7$ $\text{\textcircled{y\`i}}$   $\text{\textcircled{z\`e}}$ $\text{\textcircled{t\`u\`e}}$
 Soku 3SG-NEUTR-NCOND.AFF-PST-NIPFVPST sleep kill[PFV.HOD] at_night
 $\text{\textcircled{s\`ak\`a\`a}}$.
 well
 ‘Soku slept (lit. ‘killed sleep’) well this night.’

⁶In this paper I follow the convention of glossing these zero verb forms differently, according to the construction they occur in, i.e. '[SBJV]', '[IMP]', '[IMP_POL]', '[PFV.HOD]', and '[INF]'.

(3rd person sg. + Neutral informational status + Indicative + Affirmative + Past + Hodiernal + Perfective)

Returning now to the Apprehensional construction, we can see that the predicative marker *-ã/-ǎ* ‘APPR’ puts it in contrast with several other sentential constructions that cumulatively express different mood and polarity meanings. These constructions and their formal makeup are presented in Table 6. Examples of Negative Indicative (6) and Affirmative Indicative (7) were already given above.

In this paradigmatic set of constructions, the choice of one or another is obligatory. Even in Slot 3, the zero marker can be attributed a clear-cut, albeit idiosyncratic, semantics: it simultaneously expresses Affirmative and either Indicative, Subjunctive, Imperative, or Polite Imperative.⁸

Given that the Apprehensional construction is included in the same set, it is coherent to regard the Apprehensional as a special mood in Gban. As for its relation to polarity, at this point I will confine myself to stating that the Apprehensional construction cannot be negated/does not have a different-polarity version in any of its uses; for more details, see §7.

It is also justifiable to assign the Apprehensional construction the status of one of Gban’s core grammatical constructions (see Footnote 5), since it belongs to a closed set of obligatorily-chosen constructions constituting the grammatical categories of mood and polarity.

4 Semantics and syntax: Usage in main clauses

The Apprehensional construction can be used in main clauses as well as in dependent clauses.

In this section, I will describe the readings/functions available in main clauses: expression of pure apprehension (§4.1), warnings (§4.2), or threats (§4.3). These are illustrated in (1), (8) and (9) respectively.

⁷In this example, the null predicative markers are shown and glossed for illustrative purposes, but henceforth in the paper they will not be.

⁸I.e. Slot 3 has a zero marker only in Affirmative Indicative, Affirmative Subjunctive, (Affirmative) Imperative, and (Affirmative) Polite Imperative constructions, while having different (non-zero) markers in all Conditional, Enitive, and Apprehensional constructions and in all Negative constructions. The choice of the gloss ‘NCOND.AFF’ for this zero marker, denoting ‘Affirmative Non-Conditional’, is a simplification.

Table 6: The Mood and Polarity constructions

Meaning	Form
Affirmative Indicative	$-\emptyset$ 'NCOND.AFF' (Slot 3) ... + V (different forms) ^a
Negative Indicative	$-k\grave{e}/-\grave{a}$ 'IND.NEG' (Slot 3) ... + V (different forms)
Affirmative Conditional	$-k\ddot{e}$ " 'COND.AFF' (Slot 3) ... + V (different forms)
Negative Conditional	$-k\check{e}$ 'COND.NEG' (Slot 3) ... + V (different forms)
Affirmative Subjunctive	$-\emptyset$ 'NCOND.AFF' (Slot 3) ... + V (lexical tone) 'SBJV'
Negative Subjunctive	$-\grave{a}/-\check{a}$ 'SBJV.NEG' (Slot 3) ... + V (tonal enclitic) 'IPFV'
Imperative	$\emptyset$ '2SG.IMP' (Slot 1) + $-\emptyset$ 'NCOND.AFF' (Slot 3) ... + V (lexical tone) 'IMP'
Polite imperative	$b\ddot{e}$ '2SG.IMP_POL' (Slot 1) + $-\emptyset$ 'NCOND.AFF' (Slot 3) ... + V (lexical tone) 'IMP_POL'
Enimitive	$-\grave{a}/-\check{a}$ 'APPR/ENIM' (Slot 3) ... + V (different forms) + final particle $n\grave{i}$ 'ENIM'
Apprehensional	$-\grave{a}/-\check{a}$ 'APPR/ENIM' (Slot 3) + auxiliary verb $n\grave{u}$ 'APPR' ... + V (lexical tone) 'INF'

^aIn the constructions represented with "V (different forms)", the verb can have many forms according to other grammatical categories. In contrast to them, those constructions for which a specific verbal form is indicated, are characterized by this form as their constant feature. The dots ("...") before the verb stand for the direct object NP, if present, and/or for other minor units that can occur in this part of the clause.

(8) Warning

N-ǎ nù ké sě ě í tǝ=ě.

2SG-APPR APPR EMPH spoil[INF] you_SG GEN cloth=with

[Mother to a child who is playing with a knife, about to spoil his/her clothes:] ‘— **Don’t** spoil your clothes! / You **might** spoil your clothes!’

(9) Threat

M-ǎ nù ké ě zě!

1SG-APPR APPR EMPH you_SG kill[INF]

[In the street, a robber who wants to rob a person:] ‘— I **might** kill you / I’ll kill you!’

One of the characteristics dividing these readings is that the first one (pure apprehension) presumes undesirability for the speaker and the other two (warning and threat) undesirability for the addressee.⁹ More detailed definitions will be given in the respective subsections. It is also important to note that these readings, although they are treated separately here, are not always easily distinguishable and probably even not mutually exclusive.

A passing remark to be made here is that in Gban, main clauses with the Apprehensional construction cannot be used as questions:

(10) * *Nǝ běbèè dò y-ǎ nù bǝ ǎ nǝ lǝi?*

thing bad one 3SG-APPR APPR arrive[INF] he/she/it on Q

Intended meaning: ‘Might something bad happen to him?’

4.1 Expression of pure apprehension

First, in main clauses, the Apprehensional construction can express pure apprehension – i.e. convey just the speaker’s emotion of fear, apprehension, or anxiety

⁹I do not assert here that the inverse combinations (a pure-apprehension use with a situation undesirable for the addressee and a warning/threat use with a situation undesirable for the speaker) are logically impossible. However, it seems reasonable to assume at least that in pure-apprehension uses the situation is always undesirable **at least** for the speaker and that in warning/threat uses the situation is always undesirable **at least** for the addressee. In the first case, it seems that even if we could refer (using an apprehensional marker) to an unpreventable situation that is bad mostly for the addressee (cf. [In court, before the verdict is announced:] *Oh dear, you might get a big fine*), we would still express our own “undesiring” of it, which arises from empathy. Similarly, in the second case, even if we uttered a warning about a situation that is bad mostly for us (cf. *Watch out, you might run me over!*), it would be the addressee’s empathic “undesiring” of it that we would appeal to.

(or, probably, more neutral undesirability) with respect to some possible situation.¹⁰ It is assumed that such uses do not convey any additional illocutionary component other than expressivity.

In Gban, this pure apprehension reading is available in all three persons (which is not the case in some other languages, where person can affect the interpretation of the apprehensional construction, Vuillermet 2026 [this volume]).

Consider a series of examples with a nervous mother expressing her anxieties: with a human 3rd-person subject (11), (13b), an inanimate 3rd-person subject (12), a 1st-person subject (13a), and a 2nd-person subject (13b).

- (11) ^{OK} *Ũ nĩ bẽ y-ǎ nũ gũà.*
 we child there 3SG-APPR APPR get_lost[INF]
 [A boy has gone for a walk in a forest, alone. His parents discuss this, knowing that at the moment they can do nothing to prevent bad things from happening to him. His mother:] ‘— [I fear that] our son **might** get lost.’

- (12) ^{OK} *Nǝ bẽbèè dò y-ǎ nũ bò ǎ nẽ!*
 thing bad one 3SG-APPR APPR arrive[INF] he/she/it on
 [A constantly nervous mother, after the departure of her son, is worrying and expresses her fears aloud, talking to herself:] ‘— Something bad **might** happen to him.’

- (13) a. *M-ǎ nũ ǎ gò wò vǝũũ!*
 1SG-APPR APPR he/she/it stay[INF] put[INF] cold
 [In the same context as in (12):] ‘— [My son might get lost and] I **might** become sorrowful/anxious’ (lit. ‘... ‘stay cold/sad’)!
 b. *È nĩ bẽ y-ǎ nũ gũà. N-ǎ nũ*
 you_SG child there 3SG-APPR APPR get_lost[INF] 2SG-APPR APPR
ǎ gò wò vǝũũ!
 he/she/it stay[INF] put[INF] cold
 [In the same context, but now she speaks to the father:] ‘— Your son **might** get lost [and] you **might** become sorrowful/anxious!’

Consider also example (14) with an overcautious or squeamish person speaking.

¹⁰This function is basically what Dobrushina calls in Russian *aprexensiv* ‘apprehensive’, contrasting it with the term *preventiv* ‘preventive’ for the warning function (Dobrushina 2006).

- (14) *N-ǎ nù gà dò ì nɛ̃.*
 2SG-APPR APPR illness put[INF] I at
 [The addressee is sick. The speaker does not want to touch him/her. (S)he is explaining why (s)he does not offer his/her hand (this is the first utterance in the dialogue):] ‘— You **might** infect me.’ / ‘— For you **not to** infect me.’¹¹

All clear examples of pure-apprehension uses in my data are elicited. However, there is one example of such use from the New Testament translation:

- (15) [...] *ǎ-kě tǎ nɔ̃ ǎ mɔ̃ nù=ɛ̃*
 3SG-COND.NEG IPFV\be.NEG like_that he/she/it GEN come=LOC2
nùq=le y-ǎ nù ì gbí bò.
 constantly?=NMLZ 3SG-APPR APPR I breast remove[INF]
 {... yet because this widow keeps bothering me, I will grant her justice.}
 ‘Otherwise, she will keep coming and wear me out.’ (Luke 18:5)
 (More precisely: ‘... Otherwise (lit. ‘If it’s not like that’), her continual coming **might** upset me.’)

All the examples presented above feature situations that are inherently undesirable, so it may not yet be obvious that the Apprehensional construction itself expresses undesirability here. However, there are several examples in my data where the situations expressed by the predicates are not inherently undesirable, but are interpreted as undesirable in the context of the Apprehensional construction. This is illustrated in example (16) with ‘come’, in example (18) with ‘be/ become cold’, and especially in example (75) with ‘see my son again’.¹²

- (16) ^{OK} *M-ǎ nù nù.*
 1SG-APPR APPR come[INF]
 ‘[I **fear** that] I might come [there].’

As for the temporal localization of the situation, the Apprehensional construction in pure-apprehension uses is compatible only with future situations and not with past (17) or present (18) situations. This is similar, for example, to the apprehensive marker in Ese Ejja (Vuillermet 2018: 265), but different from the one in To’aba’ita, which is temporally-neutral (Lichtenberk 1995: 296).

¹¹This second version of the translation (Fr. ‘Pour ne pas me contaminer’) hints at a different interpretation, with a detached negative purpose clause (see §5.2), answering to a silent question ‘Why aren’t you offering me a hand?’.

¹²Examples of neutral situations are also attested in the dependent uses of the Apprehensional construction; compare (42) and (54)–(56) in the following sections.

- (17) ^{OK} *M-ǎ nù gùà.*
 1SG-APPR APPR get_lost[INF]
 1. [Worrying:] ‘– [I’m afraid that] I might get lost [in the future].’
 2. *[Worrying:] ‘– [I’m afraid that] I might have got lost [already].’
- (18) ^{OK} *Y-ǎ nù yè fǔǔfǔǔ.*
 3SG-APPR APPR be[INF] cold
 1. ‘[It would be bad for / We don’t want] it [e.g. the water] to be/ become cold [in the future].’
 2. *[I’m afraid that] it [e.g. the water] is cold [now, already].’

An interesting characteristic of the Apprehensional construction in pure-apprehension uses is that it seems to be compatible only with situations that are preventable at least in principle. *Preventability*¹³ of a situation P can be defined as the possibility of a controllable (by the interlocutors) situation Q that would cause non-P. For example, getting lost in a forest (P) is an uncontrollable situation itself, but it is preventable: the person can be or could have been persuaded (Q) not to go there. Preventability can be generic (situations that are preventable in principle, theoretically) or actual (situations that are currently preventable).

In all previous examples, the situations were at least in principle preventable (although in actual circumstances the situation may be already unpreventable). Getting infected (14) can still be prevented by not touching the sick person. The situations of one’s son getting lost (11), getting into trouble (12), or making his parents mournful (13) could all have been prevented by not letting the son go, although now it is already too late.

But consider now an example about raining, which is in principle unpreventable. In Gban, the Apprehensional construction is infelicitous in such a context:

- (19) # *Gwlé y-ǎ nù kǎ.*
 rain 3SG-APPR APPR fall[INF]
 Intended meaning: [A person comes out of the house in the morning and sees dark clouds in the sky. As today is the day of a feast (s)he is preparing, (s)he does not want rain. (S)he begins to worry:] ‘– It might rain.’

¹³I introduce here the notion of preventability, which is related to control(lability), but should be differentiated from it. A similar opposition “avertible–non-avertible” is mentioned in Lichtenberk (1995: 311).

(But a commentary was made that this could be possible for “mystic people who speak with the rain” and who thus may indeed **prevent** the rain from falling.)

At the same time, this unpreventable situation of raining (in general) can be converted into a very similar but preventable one – by introducing an additional participant (which is under the control of the interlocutors). The Apprehensional construction becomes felicitous in this case:

- (20) ^{OK} *Gwlé y-ǎ nù kǎ=lě ì mǒ wötló nǒ là.*
 rain 3SG-APPR APPR fall[INF]=LOC2 I for car that on
 [I left my car outside in the open air. I’m worried:] ‘– It might rain on my car.’

There is also a similar example in my data about the weather getting cold (which is in principle unpreventable as well). A constructed version of it with the Apprehensional construction was, too, considered infelicitous by the speaker with the commentary “It’s as if you prevent the cold from coming”.

This behaviour of the Apprehensional construction in Gban is rather peculiar, if we compare it to what is known about apprehensional markers in (some) other languages of the world. For example, the Russian apprehensional construction with *kak by ... ne* is perfectly compatible even with situations that are in principle unpreventable (21). The same is reported for Ese Ejja (Vuillermet 2018: 274). Analogous examples are found in To’aba’ita (22) and in a variety of Tatar (23).

- (21) Russian (personal knowledge)
Kak by ne pošël dožd’.
 how SBJV NEG go.PFV.PST.M.SG rain
 ‘[I’m worried that] It might rain.’
- (22) To’aba’ita (Austronesian; Lichtenberk 1995: 295)
Ada dani ka ’aru.
 APPR rain it.SEQ fall
 ‘It may rain.’
- (23) Mordovian varieties of Mishar Tatar (Turkic; Dobrushina 2006: 33)
Jaŋyyr jau-ma-yaj.
 rain fall-NEG-OPT
 ‘It might rain.’

Consider also the claim by Dobrushina that the apprehensional (“apprehensive”) “does not have a (...) restriction on controllability” and “expresses controllable as well as fully uncontrollable situations” (Dobrushina 2006: 57–59).

4.2 Warnings

Another possible use of the Apprehensional construction in main clauses is in warnings¹⁴ – i.e. in utterances that inform the addressee of an undesirable situation which the addressee can prevent if (s)he pays attention to it. One illustration of such a use is example (4) above. Consider also examples (24b), (25b), and (26) below.

It can be seen that in 2nd-person warning contexts, the Negative Subjunctive (which is, among its different uses, the standard negative counterpart to the Imperative) can also be used. In this section, the Negative Subjunctive versions are always given before the Apprehensional versions, in the (a) subexamples.

- (24) a. (Súéé,) *n-ǎ gběǎ ké!*
 watch_out 2SG-SBJV.NEG IPFV\fall EMPH
 b. ^{OK} *N-ǎ nù ké gběǎ!*
 2SG-APPR APPR EMPH fall[INF]
 [A warning to a child:] ‘– (Watch out,) **don’t** fall!’
 (Fr. ‘[Attention,] faut pas tomber’) / ‘– (Watch out,) you **might** fall!’
- (25) a. *Súéé, n-ǎ tǒ=lě ké mǐě là!*
 watch_out 2SG-SBJV.NEG IPFV\leave=LOC2 EMPH snake on
 b. *Súéé, n-ǎ nù tǒ=lě ké mǐě là!*
 watch_out 2SG-APPR APPR leave[INF]=LOC2 EMPH snake on
 ‘(Watch out,) **don’t** step on a snake! / (Watch out,) you **might** step on a snake!’ (Súéé can also be omitted.)
- (26) *N-ǎ nù ké sǐě è í tǔ=ě.*
 2SG-APPR APPR EMPH spoil[INF] you_SG GEN cloth=with
 [Mother to a child who is playing with a knife, about to spoil his/her clothes:] ‘– **Don’t** spoil your clothes! / You **might** spoil your clothes!’

¹⁴Dobrushina (2006) uses the Russian term *preventiv* ‘preventive’ for this warning function. The term *admonitive* (Russian *admonitiv*) is also sometimes used in the literature (see Vuillermet 2018: 39–40; Dobrushina 2006: 29).

The distribution of the Apprehensional and the Negative Subjunctive in these uses is not exactly clear, but there are hints that the Negative Subjunctive is more felicitous than the Apprehensional in imminent warnings, while the Apprehensional is rather used in more neutral, less urgent warnings with potential danger. In example (24), for instance, (24a) was considered by the speaker to be more felicitous than (24b) if we are trying to prevent an imminent falling, while for (24b) a more suitable context would be when the child is running or walking in the mud or any other behaviour that only can lead to a falling event. At the same time, the Apprehensional seems infelicitous in more general warnings, without a current direct motivation – see (27)–(28).

- (27) a. *N-ǎ gběǎ ké dǐ=à.*
 2SG-SBJV.NEG IPFV\fall EMPH road=on
 [A mother is warning her son before sending him to school in the morning:] ‘— **Don’t** fall along the way!’
- b. # *N-ǎ nù gběǎ ké dǐ=à.*
 2SG-APPR APPR fall[INF] EMPH road=on
 Intended meaning: ‘Don’t fall along the way!’
- (28) a. *N-ǎ sǐě ké è í tǔ=ě.*
 2SG-SBJV.NEG IPFV\spoil EMPH you_SG GEN cloth=with
 [A mother is warning her son before sending him to school in the morning:] ‘—**Don’t** spoil your clothes!’
- b. # *N-ǎ nù ké sǐě è í tǔ=ě.*
 2SG-APPR APPR EMPH spoil[INF] you_SG GEN cloth=with
 Intended meaning: ‘Don’t spoil your clothes!’
 (But example (28b) was said to be felicitous as a more direct warning, see (26) above.)

Apart from 2nd-person uses (that can be viewed as canonical for warnings), Gban also allows the Apprehensional construction with 1st- and 3rd-person subjects in warnings. An example with a 1st-person subject:

- (29) ^{OK} *M-ǎ nù vǐ dǐ è là!*
 1SG-APPR APPR throw[INF] down you_SG on
 [A person climbing down from a tree:] ‘— [Watch out there,] I **might** fall down on you!’

And a version of example (4) with a 3rd-person subject:

- (30) ^{OK} Ė kwà [y]-ǎ nù ylě!
 you_SG arm 3SG-APPR APPR break[INF]
 ‘[Be careful,] don’t break your arms!’ (lit. ‘Your arms **might** break!’)

Consider also a 3rd-person example (36) from the next section, in which the threat reading was found implausible, but which is felicitous with the reading of a friendly warning or advice.

It follows from the definition of a warning given above that, from a theoretical point of view, warnings (as well as threats, see §4.3) must introduce situations that are currently preventable, unlike pure-apprehension contexts. For example, if I am trying to warn a person that (s)he might fall (*Watch out, you might fall!*), this would only make sense if the fall is still preventable. However, it should be noted that the event *explicitly* referred to in a warning utterance needs not itself be preventable, but may just imply the possibility of some undesirable consequence which, in turn, can be prevented¹⁵ (compare ‘in-case’ contexts, discussed in the end of §5.2). For example, we could utter *Hey, it might rain today* to a person leaving the house, meaning it as a warning, for the person to take an umbrella. In this case, the warning still semantically introduces a currently preventable situation (of getting wet), but does so implicitly (as a possible consequence of raining).

Returning to Gban, here such “indirect” warnings that explicitly introduce an unpreventable situation are infelicitous. Consider example (31).

- (31) # Yĩ y-ǎ nù yèè fũfũ.
 water 3SG-APPR APPR be[INF] cold
 Intended meaning: [A person wants to swim in a lake tomorrow, but we know that the forecast is bad and we warn him/her:] ‘— The water might be [too] cold [tomorrow].’
 (But the example was said to be felicitous in the case of some small, controllable amount of water: ‘[Don’t throw ice into water,] it might be/become too cold.’)

This situation of water in a lake being cold at the time of swimming is unpreventable (regardless of the fact that it implies a possible preventable situation: a possibility for a swimmer to get cold). However, if we rather speak, for instance, about some water in a glass, this situation is preventable, and the warning becomes felicitous.

¹⁵I am grateful to the editors of the volume for bringing this to my attention.

4.3 Threats

The Apprehensional construction can also be used in threats, i.e. in utterances that express a currently preventable situation undesirable for the addressee that might be brought about (directly or indirectly) by the speaker, if the addressee does not carry out what (s)he is asked to.

There are clear examples of threat usage for the 1st and 2nd persons:

- (32) ^{OK} (N-ǎ gbíě=ě ì nĕ!)
 2SG-SBJV.NEG IPFV\drag=LOC1 I at
M-ǎ nù è zè gbĕ yě!
 1SG-APPR APPR you_SG kill[INF] knife with
 [On encountering a robber in the street, a person pulls out a knife and says:] ‘— (Don’t come any closer!) I’ll stab you (sg.)!’

- (33) a. **M-ǎ nù ké è zè!**
 1SG-APPR APPR EMPH you_SG kill[INF]
 b. **W-ǎ nù ké è zè!**
 1PL-APPR APPR EMPH you_SG kill[INF]
 [In the street, a robber or several robbers who want to rob a person:]
 ‘I might kill you / I’ll kill you!’¹⁶ / ‘We might kill you / We’ll kill you!’

- (34) **N-ǎ nù gá!** (Bě ì gbà lălă yě!)
 2SG-APPR APPR die[INF] 2SG.SBJV I give[SBJV] money with
 [A robber:] ‘— You (sg.) might die! (Give me the money!)’

- (35) **Ǻ nù ké gá gögö!**
 2PL:APPR APPR EMPH die[INF] empty
 [A robber:] ‘— You (pl.)’re gonna/might die in vain!’ [Give me that money!]

In the 3rd person, the threat interpretation of the Apprehensional construction seems to become more problematic, although it is still available. For example, in (36), the use of the Apprehensional construction was considered felicitous not with a threat reading, but rather with an advice or friendly warning reading.

¹⁶My consultant commented that this threat sounded “advice-like”.

- (36) # *N-ǎ* *tě=kpě* *ǎ* *ně, w-ǎ* *nù* *è*
 2SG-SBJV.NEG IPFV\approach=LOC1 they on 3PL-APPR APPR you_SG
kĩũũ.
 bite[INF]
 Intended meaning: [On encountering a robber in the street, a person
 with dogs threatens:] ‘— Don’t come closer! **They’ll** bite you!’
 (The following comment was given for the example: “It can’t be a
 threat; it’s like advice, as if we help the robber”.)

However, in example (37), the threat interpretation was considered possible.

- (37) *Y-ǎ* *nù* *gà!* (*Bě* *ì gbà* *lălă* *yě!*)
 3SG-APPR APPR die[INF] 2SG.SBJV I give[SBJV] money with
 [A robber has caught the wife of the man he wants to rob and threatens
 him:] ‘— **She might** die! (Give me the money!)’

Another observation on threat uses is that, in general (for all persons), the threat interpretation seems to be most felicitous when the Apprehensional construction is accompanied by a preceding imperative/prohibitive clause, as in (32). However, the problem for the analysis of such examples is that in this case they become indistinguishable from syntactically dependent negative-purpose uses without an overt subordinator (see §5.2).

5 Semantics and syntax: Dependent uses

In this section, I will describe the two attested dependent uses of the Apprehensional construction, i.e. uses in complements of ‘fear’ predicates (and probably in negative irrealis complement clauses, too) (§5.1) and in negative purpose clauses (but not in ‘in-case’ contexts) (§5.2).

When the Apprehensional construction is used in dependent clauses, it is combined with certain markers of subordination. These additional subordinators will also be discussed, in the respective subsections.

5.1 ‘Fear’ predicate complement

The Apprehensional construction can be used in the complement clauses of ‘fear’ predicates such as *gbě* ‘be afraid’, where it simply introduces the mental content associated with the ‘fear’ predicate; see examples (38)–(44) and (49)–(50) below.

Here the Apprehensional competes with the Negative Subjunctive (38b), (40b) and with the Indicative (40c), (43) with no obvious difference in semantics, although with some restrictions (see below).

The complement clauses are introduced by the complementizer *ní* ‘that’ (in some cases considered optional, see (49)). This marker *ní* (of uncertain etymology) is the default complementizer in Gban, used with verbs of speech and thought and in irrealis clauses with matrix predicates such as ‘make (somebody do something)’, ‘prevent’, ‘have to’, ‘need’, and ‘want’. It is also used as a subordinator introducing purpose clauses (see §5.2). The same *ní* can be used as a quotative marker to introduce direct speech.

- (38) a. *ǀ gbɛ́ [ní ù ní bɛ́ y-ǎ nú gùǎ].*
 1SG IPFV\be_afraid **that** we child there 3SG-APPR APPR get_lost[INF]
 b. *ǀ gbɛ́ [ní ù ní bɛ́ y-ǎ gǔǎ].*
 1SG IPFV\be_afraid **that** we child there 3SG-SBJV.NEG IPFV\get_lost
 [A boy has gone for a walk in a forest, alone. His parents discuss this, although at the moment they can do nothing to prevent anything that can happen to him. His mother:] ‘— I fear **that** our son **might** get lost.’

- (39) [...] wǝ-é *gbɛ́ [ní y-ǎ nú bato*
 3PL-IPFV.PREH IPFV\be_afraid **that** 3SG-APPR APPR ship
dɛ́-ka=le Siite yɛ́-tu kpaa=nú][...]
 stop-CAUS[INF]=LOC2 Syrtis sand-heap big=PL
 ‘Because they **were** afraid they **would** run aground on the sandbars of Syrtis,’ {they lowered the sea anchor and let the ship be driven along}.
 (Acts 27:17)
 (More precisely: ‘They **feared** **that** it [= the wind] **might** make the ship run aground at the large sandbank of Syrtis [...].’)

- (40) a. *ǃ gbɛ́ [ní Flǎsósá (y)-ǎ nú gǎ].*
 3SG IPFV\be_afraid **that** François 3SG-APPR APPR die[INF]
 b. ^{OK} *ǃ gbɛ́ [ní Flǎsósá y-ǎ gǎ].*
 3SG IPFV\be_afraid **that** François 3SG-SBJV.NEG IPFV\die
 c. ^{OK} *ǃ gbɛ́ [ní Flǎsósá " sɛ́ ǃ gǎ].*
 3SG IPFV\be_afraid **that** François 3SG IPFV\can 3SG IPFV\die
 ‘She’s afraid **that** François **might** die.’
 (A commentary was made that the Apprehensional version (40a) conveys here a preventive meaning, for example if François wants to go to a place where there is a mortal danger.)

The dependent status of these clauses is at least partially confirmed by a) the possible occurrence of a clause-final subordinator *lě* (see below) and b) the observed absence of deictic shift, as in (41). The absence of deictic shift manifests itself in that pronominal elements in the clause are chosen according to the primary speaker's perspective, as in traditional indirect speech/thought: *You're afraid lest you might fall ill* (which, in case of clauses expressing mental content, is associated with subordination and not with main clause status). They are not shifted according to the internal perspective of the participant, as they would be in direct speech/thought, i.e. in a quote: *You're afraid [saying/thinking to yourself]: "I/You might fall ill"*.

- (41) ^{OK} *Ā gbĕ* [*nĭ à* *bò y-ă* *nŭ kpõ*
 2PL IPFV\be_afraid that you_PL head 3SG-APPR APPR break[INF]
(lě).
 because
 'You (pl.) are afraid that you (pl.) might fall ill' (lit. '... that your (pl.) head might break').

Interestingly, in several of the translated examples, the 'fear' predicate complement clause was marked not only with the subordinator *nĭ* 'that', but also, optionally, with the dedicated clause-final reason/purpose marker *lě* 'because, in order to'; see examples (41)–(42). In these cases, the marking was thus identical to the one used in negative purpose clauses (see §5.2). Moreover, such marking seems to be possible even in 'fear' complement clauses that do not contain the Apprehensional construction, see example (43) with the Indicative.

- (42) *Ī gbĕ* [*nĭ w-ă* *nŭ ă* *vò* *bò bĕ*
 1SG IPFV\be_afraid that 3PL-APPR APPR he/she/it already head take[INF]
^{OK}(*lě*)].
 because
 [A person who is late:] '— I'm afraid they might already start [without me].'
- (43) *Ī gbĕ* *nò* [*nĭ yěě* *fŋŋfŋŋ* ^{OK}(*lě*)].
 1SG IPFV\be_afraid here that 3SG:IPFV\be cold because
 'I'm afraid it [water from the fridge] might be too cold.'

Apart from *gbĕ* 'be afraid', similar complement-clause uses have been attested with some other, synonymous, predicates, such as 'worry':

- (44) *ǀ gbí " vǔ [ní y-ǎ nǔ gǔà].*
 I breast 3SG IPFV\stir that 3SG-APPR APPR get_lost[INF]
 'I worry/fear (lit. 'my breast is stirring') that he might get lost.'

As for the temporal localization of the situation, the Apprehensional construction in a 'fear' predicate complement is compatible only with future/posterior readings (illustrated by any of the examples above). For past/anterior and present/simultaneous situations, other constructions must be used, like the Indicative:

- (45) a. *ǀ gbè [ní é yà bàà wíě].*
 1SG IPFV\be_afraid that 3SG\PST go_away\PFV.HEST village
 yesterday
 'I'm afraid that he might have gone to town yesterday.'
- b. **ǀ gbè [ní y-ǎ nǔ yà /*
 1SG IPFV\be_afraid that 3SG-APPR APPR go_away[INF]
yà bàà wíě].
 go_away\PFV.HEST village yesterday
 Intended meaning: 'I'm afraid that he might have gone to town yesterday.'
- (46) a. *ǀ gbè nǔ [ní ǐ gǔà].*
 1SG IPFV\be_afraid here that 1SG\PST get_lost[PFV.HOD]
 'I'm afraid that I might have got lost [already].'
- b. ^{OK} *ǀ gbè nǔ [ní m-ǎ nǔ gǔà].*
 1SG IPFV\be_afraid here that 1SG-APPR APPR get_lost[INF]
 1. 'I'm afraid that I might get lost [at a later time].'
 2. *'I'm afraid that I might have got lost [already].'
- (47) a. ^{OK} *ǀ gbè nǔ [ní yěě fǔǔfǔǔ].*
 1SG IPFV\be_afraid here that 3SG:IPFV\be cold
 'I'm afraid that it [the water from the fridge] might be cold [now, already].'
- b. ^{OK} *ǀ gbè nǔ [ní y-ǎ nǔ yè fǔǔfǔǔ].*
 1SG IPFV\be_afraid here that 3SG-APPR APPR be[INF] cold
 1. 'I'm afraid that it [the water from the fridge] might be cold [at a later time].'

2. *‘I’m afraid that it [the water from the fridge] might be cold [now].’

Just like the pure-apprehension uses (§4.1), ‘fear’ predicate complement uses seem (unexpectedly) not compatible with unpreventable situations. Example (48) is infelicitous because the raining event is not preventable in principle.

- (48) # *ĭ gbĕ* [(*nĭ*) *gwlĕ y-ă* ***nù*** *kă*].
 1SG IPFV\be_afraid that rain 3SG-APPR APPR fall[INF]
 Intended meaning: [A person comes out of the house in the morning and sees dark clouds in the sky. As today is the day of a festival (s)he is preparing, (s)he does not want rain. (S)he says:] ‘– I’m afraid it might rain.’

In this case, a different construction is used, the (Affirmative) Indicative:

- (49) *ĭ gbĕ* [(*nĭ*) *gwlĕ* " *kă* *nĭnĕ*].
 1SG IPFV\be_afraid that rain 3SG IPFV\fall just_now
 ‘I’m afraid it might rain.’

If the situation of raining is converted into a preventable one by introducing a controlled participant (50), the Apprehensional construction becomes felicitous again.

- (50) ^{OK} *ĭ gbĕ* [(*nĭ*) *gwlĕ y-ă* ***nù*** *kă=lĕ* *ĭ mǝ*
 1SG IPFV\be_afraid that rain 3SG-APPR APPR fall[INF=LOC2] I for
wǝtló nǝ lă].
 car that on
 [Oh, I left my car outside in the open air.] ‘I’m afraid it might rain on my car.’ [I need to put it away.]

Consider also example (40a) with the situation of dying, where the Apprehensional construction was said to be felicitous in a case where dying is preventable (by not going to a dangerous place).

This restriction, again, makes the Apprehensional construction in Gban different from, for instance, the Russian construction with *kak by ... ne* or the English *lest*-construction:

- (51) Russian (personal knowledge)
On pereživaet, kak by ne pošĕl dožd’.
 he worry.IPFV.NPST.3SG how SBJV NEG go.PFV.PST.M.SG rain
 ‘He’s worried that/lest it might rain.’

(52) American English

I would scan the heavens anxiously on the morning of the great event, fearful lest it might rain, in which case the picnic would be called off.
(P. G. Bernard (comp.). *Years Gone By* (1967), p. 73)

The Apprehensional construction seems to be also used in complementation of some predicates other than ‘fear’. Let us consider example (53) with the predicate *lè (w)ɔ̃* ‘be good’.

- (53) *Ǻ nɛ̃ ɛ̃ lɛ̃ ɔ̃ à mɔ̃, ɛ̃-li yɔ̃ nɪ̃ mɯ*
he/she/it which 3SG IPFV\be_good you_PL for 3SG-FOC there that person
doo gà mɯ fofo gɔ̃ vɛ̃ɛ̃, ku lɛ̃ gbɪ vi do mɔ̃
only die[SBJV] person all stomach? after so then tribe whole one for
mɯ fofo bo y-ǻ nɯ̃ vò yɛ̃.
person all head 3SG-APPR APPR finish[INF] do_all[INF]
‘[I]t is better for you that one man die for the people than that the whole nation perish.’ (John 11:50)
(More precisely: ‘What is good for you is that one man would die for all people and [that] so all people of a whole nation would not perish.’)¹⁷

Since such main predicates (there are also two similar, albeit less reliable, examples in my data with the predicate *kè* ‘say/want’) do not express undesirability nor fear, such examples seem to exhibit a different phenomenon. It appears that the Apprehensional construction has expanded its use to some extent onto the more general function of marking negative¹⁸ irrealis complement clauses, in this case with a predicate of desire/positive evaluation (the normal option for this function in Gban being the Negative Subjunctive). Unfortunately, the data are too scarce here yet to make any solid claims.

5.2 Negative purpose

Finally, the Apprehensional construction is used in Gban as the *principal* means of expressing negative purpose in subordinate clauses.¹⁹ By default, it is accompa-

¹⁷In this example, there are two conjoined subordinate clauses, sharing a single complementizer *nɪ̃*, both relating to *lè (w)ɔ̃* ‘be good’ (in a cleft construction). Cf. the French translation (from *La Bible en français courant* (Société biblique française 1997)) of this passage, which is closer to Gban: *Ne saisissez-vous pas qu’il est de votre intérêt qu’un seul homme meure pour le peuple et qu’ainsi la nation entière ne soit pas détruite?*

¹⁸For the ability of the Apprehensional construction to express negation of the dependent proposition, see §7.

¹⁹It is systematically used to translate stimuli with negated purpose clauses. The Negative Subjunctive has sometimes been tolerated in such contexts, too, but was considered less felicitous.

nied in such clauses by an explicit subordination marker: the clause-final reason/purpose marker *lě* ‘because, in order to’²⁰ as in (54) and, in addition, sometimes also the clause-initial subordinator *nĩ* ‘that’, see (55a) and (56a), or the clause-initial subordinator *nĕ* ‘which; when; because’, see (57). However, negative purpose clauses without an explicit subordinator are also possible if they follow the main clause, see (55b),²¹ but not if they precede it, see (56b).

- (54) *Mă-ă nũ yà wõtłó yě, [n-ă nũ*
1SG-IND.NEG IPFV\come go_away[INF] car with 2SG-APPR APPR
nũ lě].
come[INF] **because**
‘I won’t go in a car **in order** for you **not to** come.’
- (55) a. *É lălă nĭ ĭ nĕ [nĩ m-ă nũ bĕă*
3SG\PST money give[PFV.HOD] I at **that** 1SG-APPR APPR work
(*kĕkpă*) wò (^{OK}*lě*).
another put[INF] **because**
- b. ^{OK} *É lălă nĭ ĭ nĕ [m-ă nũ bĕă kĕkpă*
3SG\PST money give[PFV.HOD] I at 1SG-APPR APPR work another
wò].
put[INF]
‘He gave me money, **so that** I wouldn’t work (anymore).’
- (56) a. ^{OK} *[(Nĩ) m-ă nũ bĕă kĕkpă wò lě], É*
that 1SG-APPR APPR work another put[INF] **because** 3SG\PST
lălă nĭ ĭ nĕ.
money give[PFV.HOD] I at
‘**In order that** I wouldn’t work anymore, that’s why he gave me money.’

²⁰This marker’s central use is to mark dependent reason clauses (usually together with the clause-initial subordinator *nĕ* ‘which; when; because’):

- (i) *Wō-é ă mĭ sŭwi wĩ yĩ=o [nĕ zĭkĕĕ=ny Ō-lĩ-é*
3PL-IPFV.PREH they for net IPFV\throw water=in **when** fisher=PL 3PL-FOC-IPFV.PREH
nĩ ă yĕ lě].
IPFV\be_that they with **because**

‘They were casting a net into the sea, **because** they were fishermen.’ (Matt. 4:18)

²¹Such unmarked dependent clauses are often hard to distinguish from main clauses expressing pure apprehension, warning, or threat. Because of this, in this section I will mostly consider examples with subordinators, which are unambiguous.

- b. * [M-ǎ **nù** běǎ kěkpǎ wò], é lǎlǎ
 1SG-APPR APPR work another put[INF] 3SG\PST money
 nǎ ì nǎ.
 give[PFV.HOD] I at
 Intended meaning: ‘In order that I wouldn’t work anymore, that’s
 why he gave me money.’

- (57) [Ké nǎ w-ǎ **nù** ù lě zè lě], [w-ǎ **nù**
 but **when** 3PL-APPR APPR we fate say[INF] **because** 3PL-APPR APPR
 yě kǎ ú nǎ], ǎ lì lě wǔ ù blě ù
 laughter put[INF] we at he/she/it FOC_OBJ because 1PL\PST we self we
 gbí kǔ, w ǎ bě.
 breast catch\PFV.HEST 1PL\PST he/she/it eat\PFV.HEST
 ‘But **so that** they wouldn’t criticize us and [**so that**] they wouldn’t mock
 us, that’s why we forced ourselves and ate it.’ (Narrative text)

It is important that in these uses the Apprehensional construction can be shown to indeed express negative purpose and not just ‘or else .../(because) otherwise ...’. In other words, they can be shown to convey a direct negation of the proposition expressed by the dependent clause. This issue will be discussed and argued for separately in §7.

In addition, as can be seen from the examples, the (non-negated) situation expressed in such uses is not necessarily feared – it is just undesirable.

The syntactically dependent status of such clauses can be demonstrated a) by the possible usage of an explicit subordinator (55a, b) by the observed absence of deictic shift (the pronominal elements are chosen according to the primary speaker’s perspective, see example (55)), and c) by the possibility of their internal (central) position in the main clause. In example (58), the negative purpose clause is inside an indirect speech clause, itself embedded in an interrogative utterance with the clause-final question particle *lii*; the negative purpose clause thus occupies a central linear position in the main clause.

- (58) Y ǎ zè [nǐ ẽ-kè **nù** ǎ
 3SG\PST he/she/it say[PFV.HOD] that 3SG-IND.NEG IPFV\come he/she/it
 zè ì nǎ, [m-ǎ **nù** **nù** lě]] *lii*?
 say[INF] I at 1SG-APPR APPR come[INF] **because** Q
 ‘Did he say that he wouldn’t inform me **so that** I wouldn’t come?’

In (59), the negative purpose clause is placed after a topic constituent related to the main clause.

- (59) a. ^{OK} (Sòkù) Sòkù bě, [nĩ m-ǎ nũ wò lě], é
 today Soku there **that** 1SG-APPR APPR cry[INF] **because** 3SG\PST
 yě kǎ nũ-kǎ ĭ nẽ.
 laughter put[INF] come-CAUS[PFV.HOD] I at
 b. ^{OK} Sòkù bě, [nẽ m-ǎ nũ wò lě], é
 Soku there **when** 1SG-APPR APPR cry[INF] **because** 3SG\PST
 yě kǎ nũ-kǎ ĭ nẽ.
 laughter put[INF] come-CAUS[PFV.HOD] I at
 ‘(Today) Soku, **so that** I didn’t cry, made me laugh.’

The dependent status of these clauses is also reflected in their ability to be used in preposition to the main clause while containing a cataphoric pronoun:

- (60) [Nẽ / ^{OK} Nĩ bĩsĩ y-ǎ nũ ǎ tó lě], Sòkù
when that bus 3SG-APPR APPR he/she/it leave[INF] **because** Soku
 é vò sò.
 3SG\PST early pass[PFV.HOD]
 ‘So that **he**_i didn’t miss the bus, **Soku**_i left [home] early.’

As it is expected for negative-purpose (precautioning) uses in contrast to main-clause (apprehensive) uses, in Gban the negative purpose clauses allow situations that are clearly undesirable only for the subject referent of the main clause, but not for the speaker, as in (55)–(56), (58), and also (61) with a generic subject.

- (61) ě yěě / W ǎ kò bòò [nĩ mũ mĩ y-ǎ
 3SG IPFV\be 3PL he/she/it IPFV\cover top **that** person body 3SG-APPR
 nũ yèkě vǔvǔvǔ lě].
 APPR do[INF] wet **because**
 {–Umbrella, what is it for?} ‘– It is (/ One covers oneself with it) **for not**
 having one’s body wet.’

The semantically affirmative counterpart to this use of the Apprehensional construction is a dedicated Purpose construction with the predicative marker wò ‘PURP’ and an unmarked form of the main verb, which combines with the same set of subordinators and may have different linear positions. See examples (62), (63), and (64). This construction is used only in affirmative purpose clauses and cannot be combined with a negative marker.

- (62) ě kũ wõ tẽnũĩ sésé là [nĩ ð wò lě
 3SG catch[INF] IPFV\put child:PL small on **that** 3PL **PURP** matter
 dǝ].
 know[SBJV?]²²
 ‘He keeps an eye on the kids **so that** they behave.’
- (63) [Nĩ ĭ w à vòtè lě], é kě ní
when 1SG **PURP** he/she/it vote[SBJV?] **because** 3SG\PST say\PFV.HEST **that**
 ě wõ lǎlǎ nǝ ĭ ně.
 3SG PSTR money IPFV\give I at
 ‘He offered me money **so that** I would vote for him.’

The negative-purpose use is arguably the most frequent use of the Apprehensional construction in Gban. At least, in the text of the New Testament, the absolute majority of examples with the Apprehensional construction – around 80% of all (149) tokens – are clear examples of negative-purpose uses.²³

Consider the following example from the New Testament, where the Apprehensional construction is paired with the standard affirmative Purpose construction:

- (64) Ke é yěké yǝ nǝ [nĩ w-ǎ nũ kě ù
 but 3SG\PST do\PFV.PREH there **that** 1PL-APPR APPR say[INF] 1PL
 gbi dǝ u blɛ u li nɛ], **ke** [ù wò a
 breast IPFV\put we self we FOC_OBJ at but 1PL **PURP** he/she/it
 dǝ Kwɛ li nɛ].
 put[SBJV?] God FOC_OBJ at
 {Indeed, we felt we had received the sentence of death.} ‘But this
 happened that we might not rely on ourselves but on God,’ {who raises
 the dead.} (2 Cor. 1:9)
 (More precisely: ‘... But it happened this way **so that** we **would not**
 want[APPR] to rely on ourselves, **but** that we **would** rely[PURP] on
 God ...’)

Moreover, in my elicitation data, French negative-purpose clauses with *pour ne pas (que)* have often been the default translation candidates even for isolated

²²The unmarked form in the Purpose construction is probably the Subjunctive form; however, its status is still unclear.

²³This might, however, still be an artifact of the general underrepresentation of interactional contexts (to which belong all other uses of the Apprehensional in Gban, apart from negative-purpose uses) in most linguistic corpora; see Vuillermet (2018: 259–260).

clauses with the Apprehensional construction, in the absence of context. For example, the sentence $\tilde{U} \ nĩ \ bẽ \ yǎ \ nù \ gwà$ in (11) was accepted first with the translation ‘For our son not to get lost’ (Fr. ‘**Pour ne pas que** notre fils se perde’), and only then with the translation ‘[I fear that] our son might get lost’. Consider also the translation ‘For you not to infect me’ (Fr. ‘**Pour ne pas** me contaminer’) proposed for (14).

For negative-purpose uses, the issue of combinability with preventable or unpreventable situations is irrelevant: negative purpose semantics by definition requires the situation to be currently preventable (at the reference time).

However, there is a related class of contexts where the issue becomes relevant: the (undesirable) ‘in-case’ contexts (Lichtenberk 1995: 297–298; Vuillermet 2018: 279–280). They consist in adverbial dependent clauses with possible undesirable consequence semantics. Such clauses express situations that may be themselves currently unpreventable, but might cause some currently preventable undesirable effects. In some languages, apprehensional markers can have such ‘in-case’ uses as well, for example, in To’aba’ita (Lichtenberk 1995: 301) and in English (*Take an umbrella with you **lest** it (should) rain*). Gban, however, does not allow using the Apprehensional construction in these contexts:

- (65) # $\acute{E} \quad tǎ \quad dīgblĩĩ \ wò, \quad nĩnĩ \ y-ǎ \quad nù \ bò.$
 3SG\ PST cloth heavy put[PFV.HOD] chill 3SG-APPR APPR arrive[INF]
 Intended meaning: ‘He put on warm clothes in case the weather gets cold’ (lit. ‘... the chill arrives’).

To make it felicitous, my consultant altered the sentence, changing the unpreventable situation into a preventable one, thus making it a negative purpose clause and no longer an ‘in-case’ clause:

- (66) $\acute{E} \quad tǎ \quad dīgblĩĩ \ wò, \quad nĩnĩ \ y-ǎ \quad nù \ ǎ$
 3SG\ PST cloth heavy put[PFV.HOD] chill 3SG-APPR APPR he/she/it
 zè.
 kill[INF]
 ~‘He put on warm clothes **so that** he wouldn’t freeze’ (lit. ‘... the chill wouldn’t beat him’).

Instead, Gban resorts to the use of other, more general constructions to express ‘in case’, none of which is dedicated to undesirable situations.

6 Diachrony

There are no data on earlier varieties of Gban, and I am also not aware of any similar-looking constructions existing in related languages. The only dedicated apprehensional construction in a closely-related language that I know of is found in Loma (Toma) (Southwestern Mande, ISO 639-3 code: tod, Glottocode: toma1245) and is based on the (unrelated) marker *míná*, which is also used in Loma in the prohibitive construction (Mishchenko 2017: 378, 379).

However, the present-day formal makeup of the Gban Apprehensional construction gives us hints about what it grammaticalized from.

The invariable auxiliary verb *nù* used in the Apprehensional construction is most likely connected with the lexical verb of motion *nù* ‘come’, but most probably indirectly, through the Prospective construction, that must have previously grammaticalized from this lexical verb. The Prospective construction features a variable (inflecting) auxiliary verb *nù* plus an infinitive form of the main verb and expresses prospective/intentional/avertive/future semantics. See (67) and (75).

- (67) *Gwă* “ *nũ* *vĩ* *dĩ*.
 stone 3SG[NPST] IPFV\come fall[INF] below
 [Watch out!] ‘The stone is going to fall!’

The predicative marker *-ǎ/-ǎ* ‘APPR’ is apparently related to an older negative marker that can be reconstructed as **-a*. The evidence in favour of this hypothesis is the following. Firstly, the Apprehensional construction itself can be argued to express negation at least in some of its uses even synchronically (see §7). Secondly, the predicative marker used in it is similar to several other Gban markers connected to negation. One is the Enimitive construction, containing an identical predicative marker (see §2), which, too, is likely to be diachronically connected to a negative morpheme: although synchronically the construction does not convey negation in any of its uses, its grammaticalization path is most probably linked to rhetorical constructions with (formal) negation (compare English *Isn’t she lovely* ≈ *She’s lovely*). Next, as was described in §3, the Negative Subjunctive predicative marker is a very similar looking morpheme *-ǎ/-ǎ* (with a slightly different morphophonology). Finally, the Negative Indicative predicative marker *-kè* ‘IND.NEG’ has an additional variant (seemingly used in rapid speech) that looks like *-à*, see (68) and (75).

- (68) *Mǎ-ǎ* *nũ* *yà* *wòtló yě*, [...]
 1SG-IND.NEG IPFV\come go_away[INF] car with
 ‘I won’t go in a car ...’ (the “full” version would be *ǎ-kè nũ* ...)

Combining these source elements, the prospective-like one and the negative one, does not immediately and easily give us the apprehensional semantics that the construction now has. But it could acquire this semantics via its usage in a dependent clause ('fear' predicate complement or negative purpose, see below).

There are two (most plausible) paths that can be proposed for the emergence of the construction and of its different attested uses/readings. Both are based on the hypothesis that the original contexts where the construction began its grammaticalization were negative purpose clauses.

The negative morpheme **-a* would be initially used in negative purpose clauses as a "normal" negation (to express negation of the dependent proposition), and a prospective/future marker *nũ* would accompany it simply to express posteriority: 'I'll leave early, so that I **won't** miss the bus'. Here the idea of (un)desirability would at first be introduced externally, by the context and by the reason/purpose subordinators *nĩ/lě* 'so that' (combined with the negation in the dependent clause), but later it could become associated with the **-a* and *nũ* elements, thus giving rise to the new non-compositional construction expressing undesirability.

According to the first scenario, after that, it could undergo insubordination (notice that even the dependent negative-purpose uses may lack overt markers of subordination, see (55b)) and spread to main-clause warning/threat uses ('Hurry up not to miss your bus' → 'Hurry up, you might miss your bus') and pure-apprehension uses. Finally, the latter uses could naturally start occurring in dependent clauses under 'fear' predicates. So the path would be as in (69):

- (69) (Negative prospective →) negative purpose → warning/threat →
pure apprehension → 'fear' predicate complement

Next, a similar, but slightly different second scenario can be proposed. It would start off similarly to the first one, but involve, at a later stage, a direct transition from negative-purpose uses to 'fear' predicate complement uses, similar to what Lichtenberk (1995: 319) (see also Schmidtke-Bode 2009: 186–187) proposes as a general path for apprehensional markers (although it is not self-evident how precisely such a transition should proceed). In this case, the main part of the path would look like (70).

- (70) (Negative prospective →) negative purpose →
'fear' predicate complement (...)

(As to the remaining warning/threat and pure-apprehension uses, there are several equal possibilities in the second scenario, all involving insubordination.

They could: a) be both derived second after first from the negative-purpose use (as in the first scenario), b) be both derived second after first from the ‘fear’ predicate complement use, or c) be separately derived from the negative-purpose use and from the ‘fear’ predicate complement use, respectively.)

There are several arguments in favour of the two scenarios proposed in (69) and (70), i.e. in favour of paths that start from negative-purpose uses rather than from ‘fear’ predicate complements (which would be the main alternative). To begin with, the Apprehensional construction seems to be compatible only with situations that are at least in principle preventable, in all its uses. This preventability requirement is perfectly natural for warning, threat, and negative-purpose uses, but it is not expected for pure-apprehension and ‘fear’ predicate complement uses (see the discussion in §4.1 and §5.1). So, this requirement is best explained as a remnant of the precedent, diachronically original use. And this points to negative-purpose and/or warning/threat uses as being the earliest ones. There is also a similar persistence in future-/posterior-orientedness of the construction, even in pure-apprehension and ‘fear’ predicate complement uses (see §4.1 and §5.1), which, too, points to negative-purpose and/or warning/threat uses as the earliest ones, because they always refer to future/posterior situations (compare Lichtenberk 1995: 320). And synchronically, the negative-purpose uses seem to be the most frequent, which might also be explained by their status as diachronically original.

There is also a separate possible argument in favour of a direct connection between negative-purpose and ‘fear’ predicate complement uses (the second scenario, similar to Lichtenberk’s (1995) one). It is that sometimes ‘fear’ predicate complement examples were translated in my data with an additional reason/purpose marker *lě*, the same one that is typical for negative-purpose uses (see (41) and (42) in §5.1).

7 The Apprehensional construction and polarity

Let us now discuss the separate issue of the relation between the Apprehensional construction and polarity/negation. As has been argued for in §6, etymologically, the predicative marker *-ǎ/-ǎ* used in it can be rather confidently traced back to a negative morpheme. Typologically, there is also a well-established link between apprehensional semantics/undesirability and negation, manifested in many languages.²⁴ So the question arises, what is the synchronic relation of the Apprehensional construction to negation in Gban?

²⁴Negative forms of moods expressing semantics of desire (optative, subjunctive, and imperative) are one of the frequent historical sources for apprehensional constructions in the languages

If we start by looking at English translations (however unreliable this first approach may be), we will see that they do not contain the negative marker *not*²⁵ for most uses/readings of the Apprehensional construction. Compare for pure apprehension: ‘I might become sorrowful’, for threat: ‘I might/will kill you!’, for ‘fear’ predicate complement: ‘She’s afraid that François might die’. As for warnings, their translations frequently contain *not*, as in ‘Watch out, don’t fall!’, but can always be paraphrased without negation: ‘Watch out, you might fall!’.

But if we turn to dependent negative-purpose uses (described in §5.2), *not* always appears in their translations, which allows us to hypothesize that (in such uses) the Apprehensional construction in Gban still truly conveys semantic negation. Let us repeat example (54) here in (71) as an illustration.

- (71) *Mǎ-ǎ nù yà wǒtló yě, [n-ǎ nù*
 1SG-IND.NEG IPFV\come go_away[INF] car with 2SG-APPR APPR
nù lě].
 come[INF] because
 ‘I won’t go in a car **in order** for you **not to** come.’

These translations alone are not enough to make such a claim, of course. For many negative-purpose examples, paraphrases of the translations are possible that do not feature *not* in the dependent clause while maintaining the same general sense. For example, for (71): ‘I won’t go in a car, **because (otherwise)** you **might** come’ or ‘I won’t go in a car, **or else** you **might** come’.

However, one can form in Gban such negative-purpose sentences with the Apprehensional construction that would be impossible to translate without negation, which would show that in such uses it must indeed convey semantic negation. We are talking about sentences with indefinite pronominal expressions such as (72).

of the world (Dobrushina 2006: 49). Often apprehensional semantics is even synchronically expressed by constructions that are grammatically negative. For example, by a specialized negator *me*: in Classical Greek (Lichtenberk 1995: 311–313); by the negative optative in Mishar Tatar (see example (23)) and Balkar; by the negative imperative in Shor, Altai, and Khakas; by the negative subjunctive with an additional marker in Russian (see examples (21) and (51)) and Urdu (Dobrushina 2006: 32–33, 36–39). In addition, ‘fear’ predicate complements are one of the typologically-relevant contexts for the so-called expletive negation (Jin & Koenig 2020) (see below).

²⁵The following holds equally for the original French translations and the occurrence of *ne ... pas* in them.

- (72) ^{OK} M ǎ yèkě [ní mǔ dō y-ǎ nù
 1SG\PST he/she/it do[PFV.HOD] that **person one** 3SG-APPR APPR
 yà].
 go_away[INF]
 [I decided to go to town with the children. But there are five of them,
 and in the taxi there were only places for me and four children. So I
 suggested that the children compete in a game; the one who loses
 stays at home.] ‘I did it, so that **someone** [out of the five] wouldn’t go.’

As can be seen from the context, the existential quantifier introduced by the indefinite expression is interpreted here as having scope over a negative operator, at the same time being under the scope of the hypothetical desire/intention predicate – which we can assume to be part of the purpose semantics: ‘(intended (someone (NOT (go))))’.²⁶

With this scopal configuration, all paraphrases without *not* in the dependent clause (that were possible before) result in wrong interpretations. *I did it, because (otherwise) someone might have gone*, would ultimately denote a different state of affairs, corresponding roughly to ‘I did it so that **no one** would go’.

Another argument in the same vein is the availability of sentences with the exclusive focus-sensitive particle *dídòǒ* ‘only’ that demonstrate a similar scopal configuration (73).

- (73) ^{OK} M ǎ yèkě [ní Zá dídòǒ y-ǎ nù
 1SG\PST he/she/it do[PFV.HOD] that Jean **only** 3SG-APPR APPR
 nù].
 come[INF]
 ‘I did [all I could], so that **only** Jean wouldn’t come [... but that others
 would].’

²⁶The semantics of purpose can be analyzed as including a component of desire/intention (together with a reason component and a modalized causal component): ‘X P-ed in order to Q’ ≈ ‘X P-ed because X **wanted** Q to happen and because X believed that P may cause Q’.

Cf. the formulation by Goddard (1991: 44) (after Wierzbicka 1989): “the meaning of these constructions [= purposive constructions – M.F.] involves the notion of *because*, in combination with the complex notion of *someone wanting something to happen ...*”. And a following analysis by Wierzbicka (1992: 409): “*I went out to get some meat = I went out because I thought: I want: I get some meat.*”

Consider also the definitions of purpose and especially of negative purpose by Kortmann (1996: 86): “Purpose (PURPOS): ‘in order to p, q’ – p is an intended result or consequence of q that is yet to be achieved”; “Negative Purpose (N_PURP): ‘lest p, q’, ‘q, in order that not p’ – not-p is an intended result or consequence of q that is yet to be achieved”. Note the low position of negation with respect to desire/intention in the latter definition.

Such examples demonstrate that in negative-purpose uses the Apprehensional construction conveys a direct negation of the proposition expressed by the dependent clause.

All other types of uses of the Apprehensional construction (i.e. non-negative-purpose uses), on the other hand, do not seem to convey such negation. Compare an intended pure-apprehension context in (74).

- (74) # *M-ǎ nù ị nĩ bẽ kèkpǎ yò wǎ.*
 1SG-APPR APPR I son there another see[INF]
 ‘(I’m afraid) I might see my son again.’

This example cannot denote a negated dependent proposition ‘[I’m afraid] I **might not see** my son again’. A commentary was given by the speaker: “[It sounds like] ‘I don’t want to see my son anymore’; this is strange, it’s as if we wished his death”. The sentence thus provides at most just the bizarre reading ‘[I’m afraid] I **might see** my son again [which is undesirable]’, which leads to it being considered anomalous.

Periphrastic means²⁷ are used to express pure-apprehension semantics if the dependent proposition needs to be negated, compare (74) and (75).

- (75) *Ị gbẹ̀ nò [nĩ mǎ-ǎ nù ị nĩ bẽ*
 1SG IPFV\be_afraid here that 1SG-IND.NEG IPFV\come I child there
kèkpǎ yò wǎ].
 another see[INF]
 [A constantly nervous mother, after the departure of her son, is worrying and expresses her fears aloud, talking to herself:] ‘– I’m afraid I **might not see** my son again.’

Compare also a ‘fear’ predicate complement example such as (76), where an interpretation of the Apprehensional construction with a negated dependent proposition (i.e., ‘I’m afraid I might not work anymore’) is again unavailable (and the same periphrastic means as in (75) would be used to get this interpretation).

- (76) ^{OK} *Ị gbẹ̀ [nĩ m-ǎ nù bẽ kèkpǎ wò].*
 1SG IPFV\be_afraid that 1SG-APPR APPR work another put[INF]
 ‘I’m afraid to work again [i.e. I don’t want to work anymore].’

²⁷In (75), we see a combination of an explicit ‘fear’ predicate and a complement clause with the (Negative) Indicative plus an instance of the peripheral Prospective construction with the variable (inflecting) auxiliary *nù* ‘come’ (see §6).

We can see that semantically these uses of the Apprehensional construction do not convey negation of the dependent proposition. However, the question remains whether the construction still has some (weaker) connection to negation even in these (non-negative-purpose) uses.

First, if we accept the above analysis for negative-purpose uses, where it does express negation, then the whole construction can be seen as formally (grammatically) negative.²⁸ Then in non-negative-purpose uses it is formally negative, too. In other words, the construction in these uses may still represent an instance of the grammatical category of (Negative) Polarity, even though semantically “de-activated”. Such a state of affairs corresponds to the phenomenon of the so-called expletive negation.²⁹ At its extreme, such an analysis may imply that there is a formal negation, but it is fully devoid of negative force and semantically vacuous – this would correspond to a traditional understanding of expletive negation, cf. Espinal (1992).

Second (and regardless of its connection to the grammatical category of Polarity), the Apprehensional construction in these uses may express some semantic component(s) indirectly related to negation. Such a state of affairs would be similar to the way Abels (2005) analyzes the expletive negation in Russian apprehensional sentences with *kak by ... ne*: as mirroring a negative operator somewhere higher in the semantic structure than the proposition in which it occurs. In our case, this negative operator would be related to the notion of undesirability itself (given that undesirability can be seen as a contrary negation of desire). Another (typological) analysis of expletive negation by Jin & Koenig (2020) states, in a similar vein, that expletive negation reflects an entailed (or implied) negated version of the dependent proposition that is activated alongside it. ‘Fear’ predicates are analyzed as activating two contrasting propositions at the same time: *p*, corresponding to the Speaker’s attitude (what is feared), and $\neg p$, corresponding to the Speaker’s desires (what is wanted) (Jin & Koenig 2020: 22). For example, in *I*

²⁸This is a possibility because, as was shown in §3, mood and polarity categories are always expressed together in Gban by a single paradigm of cumulative predicative markers. Therefore the predicative marker *-ǎ/-ǎ* ‘APPR’ could be analyzed as always expressing not only the Apprehensional Mood, but also the Negative Polarity, i.e. ‘APPR.NEG’ (just like, e.g. *-kě* ‘COND.NEG’ cumulatively expresses in Gban the Conditional Mood and the Negative Polarity).

²⁹Expletive negation can be defined as “a construction where a negator is grammatically licensed but does not contribute to the polarity of the proposition which contains it” (cf. French *J’ai peur qu’il ne pleuve demain*. ‘I fear that it will rain tomorrow’) (Jin & Koenig 2020: 1).

In fact, we find an unambiguous case of expletive negation in Gban with a different construction, the Negative Subjunctive, which competes with the Apprehensional construction in ‘fear’ predicate complements. It is (this time undoubtedly) grammatically negative and in these uses it is devoid of negative force. Compare (38b) and (40b).

fear that I might miss the train, the dependent proposition *p* is ‘I miss the train’, while its negated version $\neg p$, ‘I don’t miss the train’, is introduced via an entailed desire predicate.

Support for there being at least some synchronic connection to negation even in non-negative-purpose uses of the Apprehensional construction comes from the fact that Gban negative polarity items (NPIs) such as *nǎ dònĩ* ‘anything (at all)’ or *mũ dònĩ* ‘anyone (at all)’³⁰ can occur in its scope both in its negative-purpose uses (77) (with negation of the dependent proposition) and its other uses (without such negation). My data provide such examples for pure-apprehension (78) and ‘fear’ predicate complement uses (79), (80).

- (77) OK Ę *kũ wõ tẽnũĩ sésé là [ní w-ǎ nù sǐě nǎ dònĩ yě].*
 3SG catch[INF] IPFV\put child:PL small on that 3PL-APPR APPR
 spoil[INF] **thing any** with
 ‘He keeps an eye on the kids so that they don’t spoil anything.’
 (a negative-purpose use)

- (78) OK *Tẽnũĩ sésé, w-ǎ nù sǐě nǎ dònĩ yě!*
 child:PL small 3PL-APPR APPR spoil[INF] **thing any** with
 ~ ‘[I’m afraid that] the kids might spoil something (lit. ‘anything’).’
 (a pure-apprehension use)

- (79) OK Ĩ *gbè [ní w-ǎ nù sǐě nǎ dònĩ yě]!*
 1SG IPFV\be_afraid that 3PL-APPR APPR spoil[INF] **thing any** with
 ‘I’m afraid that they might spoil something (lit. ‘anything’).’
 (a ‘fear’ predicate complement use)

In fact, in these latter (non-negative-purpose) uses, these NPIs compete with indefinite expressions such as *nǎ dò* ‘something’ or *mũ dò* ‘someone’, compare (80a) and (80b).

- (80) a. OK Ĩ *gbè [ní mũ dò y-ǎ nù ĩ mĩ].*
 1SG IPFV\be_afraid that person one 3SG-APPR APPR I hit[INF]
 ‘I’m afraid that someone might hit me.’
 (a ‘fear’ predicate complement use)

³⁰These items are also used as emphatic irrealis non-specific indefinites in contexts such as ‘Find at least someone!’ (but not as free-choice indefinites).

- b. ^{OK} *ĩ gbɛ̃* [nĩ mũ̃ dònĩ y-ǎ nũ̃ ĩ mɛ̃].
1SG IPFV\be_afraid that person any 3SG-APPR APPR I hit[INF]
‘I’m afraid that someone (lit. ‘anyone’) might hit me.’
(a ‘fear’ predicate complement use)

8 Conclusions

This paper described the Apprehensional construction in Gban, including its formal properties, paradigmatic status, different main-clause and dependent uses, its relation to negation, and possible diachronic sources.

The Apprehensional can be regarded as a special mood in Gban and the Apprehensional construction as one of Gban’s core grammatical constructions. It is compatible with all three persons, both in dependent and in main-clause uses. It is also compatible not only with agentive ([+control], e.g. ‘kill’), but also with some non-agentive ([–control], e.g. ‘get lost’) situations.

In main clauses, the following readings/functions of the Apprehensional construction have been identified: pure apprehension, warning, and threat. In the former function, it expresses undesirability for the speaker, in the latter two undesirability for the addressee.

In dependent clauses, two different uses have been attested. First, the construction can be used (together with certain subordination markers) in complement clauses of ‘fear’ predicates. Second, it is used in negative purpose clauses (and probably also in some types of negative irrealis complement clauses).

In the negative-purpose uses, the dependent clause is frequently marked by explicit subordinators, although it may remain unmarked if it follows the main clause. The latter makes some examples of negative-purpose uses hard to distinguish from main-clause uses, compare ‘Hurry up not to miss your bus’ (negative purpose) and ‘Hurry up, you might miss your bus’ (warning). The negative-purpose use seems to be the most frequent use or at least one of the most frequent uses (around 80% of all occurrences in the New Testament) of the Apprehensional construction in Gban.

In all of its uses, the Apprehensional construction seems to have a peculiar general restriction: even in pure-apprehension uses and ‘fear’ predicate complement uses, it appears to be compatible only with situations that are at least in principle preventable (i.e. that in principle allow another, controllable, situation that would cause the situation in question not to take place). The lack of ‘in-case’ uses, which would allow situations that are in principle unpreventable, also can be attributed to this restriction.

Regarding the diachronic sources of the Apprehensional construction, it can be conjectured to derive from a combination of an older negative morpheme and a marker expressing prospective/future semantics. The most plausible paths for its grammaticalization are ones starting with negative-purpose uses, such as: “(negative prospective →) negative purpose → warning/threat → pure apprehension → ‘fear’ predicate complement”. Or, alternatively, a similar path that would feature a direct transition “negative purpose → ‘fear’ predicate complement”.

Finally, concerning the (synchronic) relation of the Apprehensional construction to negation, it can be shown to convey negation of the dependent proposition in negative-purpose uses and it also most probably retains some weaker formal and/or semantic connection to negation in other uses (as expletive negation). In all of its uses, the construction is compatible with negative polarity items such as *nǝ dònǝ* ‘anything (at all)’.

Abbreviations

1/2/3	1st/2nd/3rd person	IPFV	imperfective
1PL_INCL	1st person plural inclusive	LOC1/LOC2	locative applicative markers
AFF	affirmative	N-	non-
APPR	apprehensional	NEG	negation
CAUS	causative	NEUTR	neutral informational status
COND	conditional	NIPFVPST	non-imperfective-past
EMPH	emphasis	NMLZ	nominalization
ENIM	enimitive	NCOND	non-conditional
FOC	focus	OPT	optative (Mishar Tatar)
FOC_OBJ	object focus	PFV	perfective
GEN	genitive	PL	plural
HEST	hesternal (past)	PREH	pre-hesternal (past)
HOD	hodiernal (past)	PRSV	presentative
IMP	imperative	PST	past
IMP_POL	polite imperative	PURP	purpose
INCL	inclusive	Q	interrogative particle
IND	indicative	SBJV	subjunctive
INF	infinitive	SEQ	sequential (To’aba’ita)
		SG	singular

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